

Singapore–Cambridge GCE O Level English Language (Syllabus 1184) Paper 2 — Comprehension Practice Paper 25

Time allowed: 1 hour 50 minutes

Total marks for Sections B and C: 45

Instructions to candidates

- Answer **all** questions in Sections B and C.
- The number of marks is given in brackets [] at the end of each question.
- Answer in **complete sentences** where instructed.
- For the summary in Section C, write **no more than 80 words**, not counting the words given to help you begin.

Section B — Text 3 (Narrative) [20 marks]

Text 3: A village woman walks the long route to a working well after her own borehole has run dry.

1

The pump in our yard had coughed its last on a Tuesday, and so by Friday I had joined the women who walked. I was up before the chickens, the empty jerry can already cool against my hip, the path to the lower well unrolling itself in front of me like a length of pale cloth. There was no question of complaint. The well was where it had always been; the borehole was where it had failed. The earth, having decided the matter, did not invite further discussion.

2

The ground between our hut and the well was a thing I had walked over for thirty years without ever quite looking at it. Now, with the jerry can swinging light and accusing at my side, I saw the cracks for the first time. They ran across the field in long, polite lines, like seams in something carefully sewn and then allowed to split. Here and there a tuft of brittle grass clung on, the way a person clings on to a habit when there is nothing else left. The dust rose around my ankles in small reluctant clouds.

3

By the time the sun was properly up, the horizon had begun to bend. I do not mean that as a poetic flourish: the heat lifted off the earth in shimmering sheets, and the line where the sky met the land trembled like a thread in a draught. The mango trees in the far distance seemed to hover, just slightly, above their roots. I had been warned, in my girlhood, never to stare too long at a heat-bent horizon, lest it teach the eye to lie. I kept my gaze, instead, on the path two paces ahead of my feet.

4

Other women joined me at the crossing by the dry stream. Mama Adaeze, who walked stiffly now after her hip operation; young Ifeoma, whose baby had been strapped to her back since dawn; the schoolteacher's widow, who never spoke much but nodded a greeting that could have meant anything. We did not, on these walks, talk a great deal. There was something in the act of walking together that made talking feel

beside the point. Our shadows, stretched and thin, walked in front of us in a neat companionable row, and that, for now, was conversation enough.

5

At the well, the pulley creaked in the same uncomplaining voice it had used in my mother's time. The water, when at last it came up in the bucket, was colder than I had any right to expect, and it caught the light in a way that made even the most exhausted woman pause for a second to look. We filled in turn, by an order so old that no one any longer remembered agreeing to it. Mama Adaeze first; then Ifeoma, because of the baby; then the widow; then me. I screwed the cap tight, tested the weight, and balanced the can on my hip the way one balances any necessary burden — carefully, so that one's back may last.

6

The walk home is the walk that teaches you things. On the way out, a body is light, and the mind runs ahead of itself, planning. On the way back, a body is honest. Twenty litres on a hip is twenty litres on a hip; the path lengthens; the sun, which was so encouraging an hour ago, becomes a frank and unhelpful witness. I thought, as I walked, of my eldest son, who lives now in the city and who tells me, gently, that this is no life. I thought of my mother, who walked this same path before there was even a borehole to fail. I thought of nothing for long stretches at all.

7

There is a kind of dignity, I have decided, in an unglamorous routine. It is not the dignity of speeches or of statues; it is smaller and quieter than that. It is the dignity of being relied upon. The water in my can would wash a small face, soften a pot of beans, fill a kettle for my husband's tea. None of these things would be noticed. All of them would be missed, instantly and bitterly, if they did not happen. A life, I sometimes think, is mostly made of such unnoticed things.

8

At the gate, I set the can down carefully, straightened, and pressed both hands into the small of my back. The yard was already noisy: the goat complaining; the youngest grandchild laughing at something only she could see; my husband, who has bad knees, calling from the doorway to ask whether the water was good today. I told him it was. I did not say what else I had been thinking on the walk. Some thoughts, like some water, are best kept covered, and carried home quietly, where they belong.

From Paragraph 1

1. The narrator says, "There was no question of complaint." Explain, in your own words, what this tells us about her attitude to the failure of the borehole. [2]

2. In Paragraph 1, the narrator says the earth "did not invite further discussion." What does this **personification** of the earth suggest about her view of the situation? [2]

From Paragraph 2

3. The narrator compares the cracks in the ground to "seams in something carefully sewn and then allowed to split." Explain what this comparison suggests about the land. [2]

4. The narrator writes that the grass clings on "the way a person clings on to a habit when there is nothing else left." What does this image suggest about the **condition** of the landscape? [1]

From Paragraph 3

5. The narrator says the horizon had “begun to bend.”

- (a) What does she mean by this, in plain terms? [1]
(b) Why does she keep her eyes on “the path two paces ahead of my feet”? [1]

From Paragraph 4

6. Give **two** details from Paragraph 4 that show the women have **little need** to speak on these walks. [2]

From Paragraph 5

7. The narrator says she balances the can “the way one balances any necessary burden — carefully, so that one’s back may last.” Explain how the language here suggests that this routine has been learned over a long time. Support your answer with **two** details from Paragraph 5. [3]

From Paragraph 6

8. The narrator says the sun becomes “a frank and unhelpful witness” on the walk home. What does this phrase suggest about how she feels on the return journey? [2]

9. The narrator says her son tells her, “gently, that this is no life.” What does the word **gently** suggest about the relationship between mother and son? [1]

From Paragraph 7

10. The narrator says, “A life, I sometimes think, is mostly made of such unnoticed things.” Explain, in your own words, what she means. [2]

From Paragraph 8

11. What is the **tone** of the final sentence of the text? [1]

Section C — Text 4 (Non-narrative) [25 marks]

Text 4: A feature article on the deepening problem of water scarcity in Asian cities.

1

In June 2019, the residents of Chennai woke up to a startling headline: their city, home to more than ten million people, had effectively run out of water. The four reservoirs that supplied the metropolis had shrunk to puddles of cracked mud; tankers, escorted by police, became the new arteries of daily life. The episode, dubbed “Day Zero,” was not a freak event. It was, in the soberer assessments since, a preview. Across Asia, from Jakarta to Karachi, the question is no longer whether urban water systems will be strained, but how soon, how severely, and at whose expense.

2

The causes are interlocking and stubborn. Cities are growing at a pace that few water utilities were built to absorb: Asia’s urban population is projected to add over a billion people by 2050, all of whom will need to drink, wash and cook. Pipes laid in the colonial period or in the post-independence rush of the nineteen-sixties leak prodigiously; in some Indian cities, nearly forty per cent of treated water is lost between the plant and the tap. Climate change is altering monsoon rhythms, lengthening dry seasons and intensifying the brief storms that follow. Beneath the surface, aquifers are being drained faster than they refill, and increasingly contaminated by industrial run-off, fertiliser and untreated sewage.

3

Few cities illustrate the danger more vividly than Jakarta. Roughly half the Indonesian capital sits below sea level, and parts of the north are sinking by as much as twenty-five centimetres a year — among the fastest rates anywhere on earth. The cause, paradoxically, is thirst. Because the piped network reaches barely half of the city, millions of residents draw their water from private wells sunk into the soft ground. As the aquifers are pumped dry, the city above sags into the space left behind. Indonesia’s government, after years of half-measures, has now announced a wholesale relocation of the capital — a policy whose price tag and uncertainty are themselves an indictment.

4

At the other end of the spectrum lies Singapore, an island nation that imports water from Malaysia and possesses no significant aquifer of its own. For decades, this dependence was treated as a strategic vulnerability. The response has been, in retrospect, remarkable. The country has constructed an integrated portfolio of “four taps”: imported water, captured rainfall, desalination and, most famously, NEWater — treated waste water purified to a standard cleaner than most bottled brands. Today NEWater meets up to forty per cent of demand, and engineers from across the region make pilgrimages to Singapore’s plants to learn how it was done.

5

Technology, however, is not the whole story, and in some respects not even the harder part of it. The deeper question is one of distribution. In Manila, a household in a gated suburb pays a small fraction of what a household in an informal settlement pays for the same litre of water, because the informal household must buy from private vendors at marked-up rates. In Mumbai, hours of supply per day vary wildly between postcodes. Water scarcity, like many shortages, is rarely felt evenly: the wealthy bottle, recycle and pay; the poor walk, queue and ration. A pipe network is a moral document as well as an engineering one.

6

Promising responses are nonetheless beginning to multiply. Desalination plants, once prohibitively expensive, have become cheaper and more energy-efficient, and now supply a significant share of demand in cities such as Chennai and Hong Kong. Greywater recycling — reusing water from showers and basins

for flushing and gardening — is being mandated in new developments from Bangalore to Bangkok. Smart meters and leak-detection sensors are slowly being retrofitted onto colonial-era networks. Rainwater harvesting, long dismissed as folksy, is now compulsory for new buildings in much of Tamil Nadu, with measurable effect on groundwater levels.

7

And yet no plant, however sophisticated, can substitute entirely for the small daily choices of millions of citizens. A shorter shower, a fixed tap, a half-full kettle: these sound trivial set against the scale of the problem, but multiplied by a city, they are not. The mistake of the last century was to treat water as inexhaustible because it came out of a tap. The task of this century, in cities from Karachi to Kuala Lumpur, is to remember what every villager with a jerry can already knows: that water is heavy, that water is finite, and that the journey from source to glass is never quite as short as the plumbing makes it look.

From Paragraph 1

12. The writer says the Day Zero episode “was not a freak event” but “a preview.” Explain, in your own words, what the writer means by this. [2]

From Paragraph 2

13. According to Paragraph 2, give **two** reasons why Asian cities are running short of water. [2]

14. The writer says the pipes laid in earlier decades “leak prodigiously.” What does the word **prodigiously** suggest about the scale of the loss? [1]

From Paragraph 3

15. The writer says the cause of Jakarta’s sinking is, “paradoxically, thirst.” Explain, in your own words, why this is a **paradox**. [2]

16. Why does the writer call the planned relocation of Indonesia’s capital “an indictment”? [2]

From Paragraph 4

17. The writer describes Singapore’s response as “in retrospect, remarkable.” Explain how Paragraph 4 supports this judgement. Give **two** details. [2]

18. The writer puts the phrase “four taps” in **inverted commas**. What is the effect of this punctuation? [1]

From Paragraph 5

19. The writer says, “the wealthy bottle, recycle and pay; the poor walk, queue and ration.” Explain how the **structure** of this sentence makes the inequality clear. [2]

20. What does the writer mean when he says, “A pipe network is a moral document as well as an engineering one”? [2]

From Paragraph 7

21. What is the **tone** of the final sentence of the text? [1]

22. Summary question [6 marks for content, 7 marks for use of own words and style]

Using your own words as far as possible, summarise **the main causes of water scarcity in Asian cities**, and **the responses that are being made to tackle the problem**, as outlined in the text.

Use **only** material from **Paragraphs 2 to 6** of Text 4.

Your summary must be in **continuous writing** (not note form). It must **not** be longer than **80 words** (not counting the words given to help you begin).

Begin your summary as follows:

Asian cities are running short of water because ...

— END OF PAPER —